BOOKS ▶

A Classic Reimagined

MEENA ARORA NAYAK'S NEW RETELLING BRINGS THE TALES OF THE *VETALA PANCHAVIMSHATI* TO LIFE WITH TRADEMARK CLARITY AND DEEP SCHOLARSHIP

I love everything about Meena Arora Nayak's retellings: her language, the stories she chooses, the cover design of the book, the cover illustration, the layout of the pages. What I admire most is the enormous erudition that lies behind the deceptively simple and light tone in which she presents her stories and her critical material. Much as I have taken pleasure in all of Arora Nayak's books, I suspect *The Undead Ghoul* is going to be my favourite.

The *Vetala Panchavimshati* is a wonderful cycle of tales held within a truly compelling frame story of a face-off between a mysterious mendicant and a beloved king. It contains an endless universe of characters and events that allow for narrative arcs that Arora Nayak describes as "... light, capricious, and humorous, with unexpected plot twists and themes that explore life, love, sexuality, desires, relationships, and human behaviours..." The stories are filled with deceptions, betrayals and criminal acts as well as true love and the deeds of honourable men and women. And yet, as Arora Nayak points out, the stories do not lead us to judge the morality of the characters. They encourage us to think about dharma not as absolute and unbending, but as "ambiguous, often unknowable, and a matter of individual perception".

The cycle's attraction lies in the tension between the honourable, valorous king and the mendicant who exudes a kind of sinister power. He reveals his dark side when he asks the king to meet him at the burning ground where dead bodies are cremated. The king has to perform the arduous task of carrying a corpse that was hanging on a tree back and forth to the mendicant who is preparing a tantric mandala to gain more powers. The corpse has been taken over by a malevolent spirit who pesters the king with elaborate stories that end in riddles that he must answer. Every time he answers, the corpse/ *vetala* laughs and flies back to the tree where it was hanging.

Arora Nayak remarks that from this point onwards, the frame has become a ghost story set among ghouls and spirits who haunt the necropolis wrapped in a fug of burning flesh. Of course, the frame story is also a metatext that celebrates stories, story-tellers and listeners. We are fortunate that Meena Arora Nayak has profoundly understood that ancient contract and invites us to honour it, too. ■

—Arshia Sattar



THE UNDEAD GHOUL AND THE CLEVER RAJA
Twenty-five Tales of the *Vetala Panchavimshati*
By Meena Arora Nayak
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹699; 224 pages

THE LISTICLE

NOTEWORTHY AND NEW

RECENT BOOKS THAT CAUGHT OUR EYE

THOSE WERE THE DAYS

In *Doordarshan Diaries*, veteran TV anchor and talk show host Sheila Chaman takes us back to the pre-satellite TV era when only one channel ruled the air waves. She tells the story of Doordarshan in the form of a personal memoir—outlining how she started working there; the pre-colour days; the 1980s, when Doordarshan truly started transforming and coming into its own—beginning with its first colour broadcast on April 25, 1982 (which was a test run), followed by the first nationwide colour telecast on Independence Day the same year with the prime minister's speech; and subsequent decades when development came at a much faster pace. Chaman, who was a bilingual presenter—a prized skill in those days—writes with charm and grace.



DOORDARSHAN DIARIES
The Golden Era of Television
By Sheila Chaman
Om Books
₹395; 219 pages

